

Being named in a scam is a blot on anyone's career. Not so for Pratik Gandhi. In October 2020, the Gujarati actor earned praise for his pitch perfect act as Harshad Mehta in the web show *Scam 1992*. Says Pratik, "Something like it happens once in a lifetime and that too not for everyone." The 43-year-old is finally seeing the fruits of that career-changing act now. March saw the release of the hilarious buddy comedy *Madgaon Express*; on April 19, he will be seen alongside Vidya Balan in *Do Aur Do Pyaar*, a romantic comedy about two adulterous couples. In addition to this, Pratik has wrapped up six other features. He is currently shooting *Gandhi*, a web series on the father of the nation which sees him collaborating with Hansal Mehta again.

A lot has changed for Pratik in the past few years. For starters, he has changed pin codes—shifting from Kandivili to the tony suburb of Juhu, his apartment only a stone's throw away from Amitabh Bachchan's. His inbox is full of pitches so much so that he admits there are at least 25 scripts he has yet to read. His calendar, too, is packed, but he still makes space for his first love—theatre. On April 14, Pratik performs his one-man act, *Mohan No Masalo*, a Gujarati monologue on Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi before he became the Mahatma, at the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre in Mumbai. "Theatre calms me down, it keeps me grounded," says Pratik, "and it's always therapeutic to be on stage."

For many in the theatre fraternity, his rise has instilled hope. "I could see a lot of excitement in makers and writers," adds Pratik. Actors, too, reached out to him. "They felt they could relate to my personal journey. They felt one of us had made it. It was heartwarming to see that." That sense of relatability stems from Pratik being a late bloomer in Bollywood. *Scam* released when he was 40. Pratik wouldn't have his career pan out any other way. "All of the knowledge and experience helped me perform [in *Scam*]," he says. The said experience came from balancing a job in Reliance Infrastructure and doing experimental plays in Gujarati and Hindi.

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OUT OF THE SHADOWS

JAI MEHTA makes his directorial debut with Disney+ Hotstar's web series *Lootere*

For a long time, Jai Mehta's identity was defined by his famous father, the National Award-winning director Hansal Mehta, best known for his indie filmmaking credentials. Mehta Jr assisted the senior on acclaimed films like *Shahid* and *Aligarh* before finally graduating to earn co-directing credits on the popular web series *Scam 1992*. During the decade-long association, he admits being a bit of an idealist after each project ended. "I'd be like *iske baad main film banaoonga* [I'll make a film after this]," says Jai. After eight years of pitching scripts—he has written five features—Mehta finally got to sit in the director's chair, all by himself. With Disney+ Hotstar's web series *Lootere*, Jai shows off his cinematic prowess, vision and even flair. And going by the five episodes so far, it's distinct from his father's work.

Lootere has a lot going on. It's got Somali pirates who hijack a Ukrainian vessel with Indian crew members, who in turn are trying to escape or hide. There's an Indian businessman (Vivek Gomber) desperately trying to hold on to power in Somalia. His wife is looking for her help's missing teenage son. Shot extensively in Cape Town, the eight-episode show is as much a tense survival thriller as it is a drama that explores the disparities between the haves and the have-nots. "I wanted to bring the big screen experience into a series," says Jai.

Initially offered to Hansal, whose